Playwriting 101: The Rooftop Lesson

By Rich Orloff

(Pg 269-280) *(THE JUMPER is on the ledge of the roof and is about to jump.)*

JUMPER: I'm going to jump, and nobody can stop me! *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN enters quickly.)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: Don't!!!!! *(THE TEACHER enters, points a clicker at the others and clicks, freezing the action.)*

TEACHER: *(addressing the audience)* A typical dramatic scenario: Two people in conflict-at least one in deep inner conflict with high stakes, suspense, and affordable cast size. How will this situation play out? That depends, of course, on the level of craft and creativity in that remarkable art form known as playwriting. Let's rewind from the start and see what happens. *(THE TEACHER clicks, and THE JUMPER and GOOD SAMARITAN return to their places quickly)*

JUMPER: I'm going to jump, and nobody can stop me!

GOOD SAMARITAN: Don't!!!!!

JUMPER: Okay. *(THE TEACHER clicks to freeze the action.)*

TEACHER: Not very satisfying, is it? Where's the suspense? Where's the tension? And what audience member will want to pay today's ticket prices for a play whose conflict resolves in forty-five seconds? But most importantly, where can you go from here? *(THE TEACHER clicks to unfreeze)*

INTRODUCTION

Cliché – A saying, image or idea which has been used so much that it should terribly uncreative. Using cliché's is considered BAD writing because they make it sound like you didn't put any thought into your words. Satire – The use of humor, exaggeration or ridicule to expose and criticize people's stupidity. Politicians and, in this case, playwrights are easy targets – especially when they're acting self-righteous! In Playwriting 101: The Rooftop Lesson, Rich Orloff masterfully combines Cliché and Satire to create something . . . something . . . . Something that will make you want to jump off a roof! Playwriting 101: The Rooftop Lesson by Rich Orloff.

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GOOD SAMARITAN: Gee, you could've hurt yourself.

JUMPER: Gosh, you're right. *(THE TEACHER clicks to freeze the action.)*

TEACHER: Without intense oppositional desires, more commonly known as "conflict," there is no play. When Nora leaves in *A Doll's House,* nobody wants her husband to reply *(upbeat)* "Call when you get work!" So let's start this scene over maintaining conflict. *(THE TEACHER clicks. THE JUMPER and GOOD SAMARITAN rewind to their initial places.)*

JUMPER: I'm going to jump, and nobody can stop me!

GOOD SAMARITAN: Don't!!!!!

JUMPER: Why not?!!! *(THE TEACHER clicks.)*

TEACHER: Oooo, you can just feel the suspense rising now, can't you? *(THE TEACHER clicks again.)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: Because suicide is a sin! *(THE TEACHER clicks.)*

TEACHER: Big deal. Theatre is written by sinners about sinners for sinners. Nobody goes to *Othello* to hear, "Iago, you're so naughty!" Always let the audience form their own judgments. Now let's try a different tack. *(Clicks.)*

JUMPER: Why not?!

GOOD SAMARITAN: Because life is worth living.

JUMPER: Mine isn't! *(THE TEACHER clicks.)*

TEACHER: Excellent. We don't just have a plot anymore, we have a theme. Theme, the difference between entertainment and art. No theme, add a car chase and sell it to the movies. But with theme, you have the potential to create something meaningful, something memorable. *(THE TEACHER clicks again to resume.)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: Because life is worth living.

JUMPER: Mine isn't!

GOOD SAMARITAN: Are you sure?

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JUMPER: Yes, I'm sure. I'm broke, I have no friends, and I see no reason to continue.

GOOD SAMARITAN: Look, so you're broke and friendless. All experiences are transient. Detach, as the Buddha once did. *(THE TEACHER clicks.)*

TEACHER: Of all the world's great religions, Buddhism is the least entertaining. Let's try again. *(THE TEACHER clicks again.)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: So you're broke and you're friendless. Why not try Prozac? *(THE TEACHER clicks.)*

TEACHER: The popularity and effectiveness of modern antidepressants is one of the great challenges of contemporary dramaturgy. We no more want Willy Loman to solve his problems with Prozac than we want Stanley and Stella Kowalski to get air-conditioning. *(THE TEACHER clicks again.)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: Let me help you.

JUMPER: It's too late. I haven't told you the worst. You see, until a few weeks ago, I was in love. I was involved with two of the most wonderful gals in the world. One was sexy, rich, generous and caring. The other was streetwise, daring and even sexier. Between the two of them, I had everything. Then they found out about each other, and they both dumped me. Not just one, but both. *(THE TEACHER clicks.)*

TEACHER: Excellent playwriting. Here's a heartbreaking situation with which we can all identify. Maybe not in the specifics, but in the universal experience of rejection. *(THE TEACHER clicks again.)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: At least you've had two exciting affairs. I haven't *had any relationships* in a year.

JUMPER: So what are you telling me? That life can get ***worse***? That's supposed to get me off this ledge?

GOOD SAMARITAN: Hey, I'm just trying to help!

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JUMPER: Well, you're doing a lousy job.

GOOD SAMARITAN: At least I've got some money in the bank!

JUMPER: You've also got rocks in your head! *(THE TEACHER clicks.)*

TEACHER: A common beginner's mistake. Two characters in hostile disagreement isn't conflict, it's just bickering. We don't go to the theatre to hear petty, puerile antagonism; that's why we have families. Let's hope this goes somewhere interesting. *(THE TEACHER clicks again.)*

JUMPER: You've only got money in the bank because you're cheap.

GOOD SAMARITAN: I am not.

JUMPER: Well, you certainly dress like you are.

TEACHER: Now this is really degenerating. *(THE TEACHER clicks, but the action continues.)* Now stop it ... Stop it! ... Stop it!! *(Etc.)*

JUMPER: *(Shouting above THE TEACHERS "Stop it'ts, which they ignore)* Loser!

GOOD SAMARITAN: Cretin!

JUMPER: Cheapskate!

GOOD SAMARITAN: Imbecile!

TEACHER: *(clicking in vain)* ***Stop it!!!!*** *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN takes out a clicker and freezes THE TEACHER.)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: Notice how organically the teacher's frustration has increased. What began as a minor irritation became unbearable when the human desire to control was thwarted. *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN clicks)*

TEACHER: What are you doing?! I hold the clicker around here. How dare- *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN clicks. THE TEACHER freezes.)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: See how frustration becomes "anger"? Although the real life stakes are minor, the character's emotional investment is intense. That's good playwriting. *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN clicks again.)*

TEACHER: Stop that. What do you think this is, a Pirandello play?

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GOOD SAMARITAN: Well, how do you think *we* feel? We can't say more than two lines without being interrupted by your self-important pronouncements. How'd you like it if I did that to you?

TEACHER: You have no dra- *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN clicks and stops /starts THE TEACHER during the following:)* matically vi-able rea-son to inter-rupt me. Damn it, will you get back in the play?

GOOD SAMARITAN: No, and you can't make me! *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN clicks at THE TEACHER, who dodges the clicker.)*

TEACHER: Aha, missed … You superficial stereotype! *(THE TEACHER clicks at THE GOOD SAMARITAN and vice versa during the following, both successfully dodging the other.)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: Control freak!

TEACHER: Cliche!

GOOD SAMARITAN: Semi-intellectual!

TEACHER: First draft mistake! *(THE JUMPER, who has been watching this, takes out a gun and shoots it into the air.)*

JUMPER: *Hey!!!* I'm the one with the problem. This play's supposed to be about me.

TEACHER: *(to THE GOOD SAMARITAN)* Damn it, get back into the play!

GOOD SAMARITAN: Don't tell me what to do. Ever since I was a kid, everyone's told me how I'm supposed to behave. When I was five, my mom sent me to my room *(THE TEACHER starts clicking manically at THE GOOD SAMARITAN.)* four thousand times because I wouldn't be the kid she wanted me-

TEACHER: This monologue is not justified!

GOOD SAMARITAN: It's my life!

TEACHER: It's bad drama!

GOOD SAMARITAN: I'll show you bad drama! *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN and THE TEACHER begin to fight.) (THE JUMPER tries to break up the fight.)*

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JUMPER: Come on, guys, cool it! *(The three of them are in a tight cluster. We hear a gunshot. THE TEACHER pulls away. There's blood on THE TEACHER's chest.)*

TEACHER: I just got tenure. *(THE TEACHER collapses and dies dramatically)*

GOOD SAMARITAN: Oh my God. *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN looks at THE JUMPER.)* How horrible. Is that good playwriting or bad playwriting?

JUMPER: I, I don't know. It just happened. *(THE GOOD SAMARITAN and THE JUMPER look at THE TEACHER...(simultaneously)* Hmmmmmmm.

End of Play

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AWARD HISTORY

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